

ZERO TOLERANCE TO FAILURE

DESPITE INITIAL SUCCESS, ALL STAKEHOLDERS MUST INTRODUCE CHANGES TO KEEP IPL VIBRANT AND PROFITABLE

Before arriving to be part of the Kolkata Knight Riders franchise, I believed the IPL was a vehicle to evolutionise and not revolutionise cricket. I believed it would be an event which would accelerate necessary changes to ODI format and it would be an opportunity to introduce to cricket a group of people who would not necessarily be involved, at least not so intimately, with the game—the entrepreneurs, the franchise owners.

For me, it was an incredible experience being in a dressing room of Australians, South Africans, Indians, Pakistanis, a Zimbabwean, a West Indian and a New Zealander who all had their own ways, languages and culture, plus a few country captains or former captains, a support staff that had never met, let alone worked together. Add to this mix, Bollywood and Shah Rukh Khan, and I think you begin to get the feel that there was never a dull moment.

The IPL format was readily consumed by a market which seems to have an insatiable appetite for this type of cricket. Certainly there is the novelty factor—it is new, it is different, it is lively. Even so, there was little decrease in public attendance, public viewing and public readership throughout the tournament, a significant barometer in gauging future successes.

For the IPL to continue to grow, it must always ensure it has the world's best players who are then spread amongst the best franchises. At this stage, there is a belief inside the IPL that it will be very difficult for another league to commence outside this region. This premise will hold true only if the IPL retains all the best players, and 'houses' them within their own best-run franchises. For the immediate present though, this season's format has proved to be a version the consumers are happy with. However, change is inevitable to keep IPL vibrant, fresh and profitable. I think change will revolve around a few factors:

- Salary caps, the number of foreign players in a team, and what constitutes a playing team—for example, is it 11, 12, or even more allowing for substitutes and strategies?

- The speed of the game—overcoming fac-

tors which slow the game down, for example two balls in the game to overcome ball retrieval, shortened fast bowling run-ups.

- Playing rules, to enhance competition, to reward performance, and to protect the concept of T-20. For instance, changing the dimensions and size of the inner ring to enhance/encourage better running between wickets and fielding; or rewarding direct hits on the stumps by ruling that the ball go dead immediately and not having ricochets count for runs; the measuring of slow over rates at the 10 and 15-over marks so that one or then two main bowlers cannot complete their allotted overs, someone else will have to bowl.

- Corporate hospitality and spectator comfort bundled together in the whole entertainment experience.

The IPL has work to do with the salary cap and the number of overseas players to be used per team. Each franchisee used approximately 12 players including those bought through auctions and their replacements throughout the tournament. From next year there will be an increased influx or availability of overseas players mainly from England and the West Indies, but indeed all around the globe. The rules of the tournament regarding player trading, the draft system, the format of the game itself and the promotions that give the tinsel and glitter will all require review.

While the IPL is still being accepted by all countries, the international Future Tours Program impacts significantly on players' availability and fitness. Being able to know well in advance of player departures, when and for how long will be a juggling act which, if the balls do not fall correctly, definitely works against successful performance.

I hope by the third year of its operation the ICC, along with member countries, will realise that everyone can benefit from such a competition. In most cases it is about player retention and longevity—the IPL will help subsidise players' earning capacities without each respective country trying to find ways and means of doing so. New Zealand, as it does often, has already recognised this fact by committing its players

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